CLUBSTONBURY EXPLAINED

How the lottery works

Three rounds.
One published method.

Clubstonbury puts children into a randomised order, then tries each child's clubs in preference order. It does this once for first places, again for second places, and again for third places.

The rules in plain English

1	2	3	4
Equal deadline Every valid, on-time entry joins the same lottery. Earlier submission has no advantage.	**Spread opportunity** One place each is considered before second and third places.	**Respect choices** A child gets only a club they requested, tried in their own preference order.	**Make it auditable** A recorded seed and version make the result reproducible.

Inputs to the lottery

Each child
Opaque ID + 1-3 ranked choices

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Each club
Name + available capacity

Run seed
Random value, saved for audit

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Algorithm version
Published rule set

The timestamp is retained in result files for administration but deliberately excluded from every priority calculation.

A repeatable random order

Each round uses a fresh randomised order. The saved seed lets Clubstonbury recreate those same orders exactly if the result is ever questioned.

When a child's turn arrives, their first choice is tried first. If it is full, their second choice is tried, then their third. The algorithm stops for that round as soon as it finds an available place.

What does not affect the random order: name, submission time, CSV row, number of choices, choice rank or personal characteristics.

The three allocation rounds

First place — 1

- Every child is eligible.
- Use round 1's randomised order.
- Try their requested clubs in order of preference until finding one that is open.
- Stop after at most one allocation.

Second place — 2

- Only children with exactly one place are eligible.
- Create a fresh randomised order.
- Try remaining requested clubs in preference order.
- Stop after at most one more.

Third place — 3

- Only children with exactly two places are eligible.
- Create a fresh randomised order.
- Try the last unallocated requested club.
- Stop after at most one more.

At every step: a place is allocated only when capacity remains. A club can never exceed its entered capacity, and a child can never receive an unrequested club.

A WORKED EXAMPLE

Randomised order, preference order

Round 1 order: B, C, A, D

Suppose Football has 1 place, Drama has 2 and Coding has 1. Clubstonbury randomly puts the children in the order B, C, A, D for round 1, then tries each child's choices in preference order:

Turn	Child's choices	What the algorithm does	Result
B	Football, Coding	Football is open.	**Football**
C	Drama, Football	Drama is open.	**Drama**
A	Football, Drama	Football is full; next-ranked Drama is open.	**Drama**
D	Coding, Drama	Coding is open.	**Coding**

Everyone has one club, and every capacity is now full. No one can receive another place in rounds 2 or 3. A's lower-ranked Drama choice helped A; ranking it did not change A's chance at Football.

The algorithm in one line: randomised child order; clubs tried in each child's preference order.

What happens after everybody has been considered once?

Try for a second club 2

Children with exactly one club are put into a fresh randomised order. Their remaining choices are tried in preference order.

Try for a third club 3

Children with exactly two clubs are put into another randomised order. Their remaining choice is tried.

Create waiting lists ↻

Every requested club a child did not receive is included on that club's reproducible waiting list. Schools decide how to use it.

Rules that stay the same

- A club is allocated only while it has capacity.
- A child receives only clubs they requested.
- Lower-ranked choices are tried only after higher-ranked choices are unavailable.
- Submission time and CSV row order do not affect the random order.

Mop-up is first come, first served. In the published workflow, late or changed requests are handled after the original allocation and waiting-list process.

Rerun a questioned result

Keep these four things together:

1	2	3	4
Applications CSV	Club capacities	Run seed	Algorithm version

Put them back into Clubstonbury to reproduce the same random orders and allocations. This lets an administrator demonstrate that a challenged result has not changed.

Scope: Clubstonbury applies this published model; it does not decide eligibility or legal priority. The administrator must confirm the model suits the school's policy, check all data and results, and apply any duties or reasonable adjustments outside the algorithm.